



A wiki can handle a number of different tasks

a central server and not spread across a number of terminals. Also, centralised handling and storage of content makes sure no data is lost if one of the local terminal crashes.

The most common operations on a wiki, such as editing and creating pages of content, and managing schedules including the control functions on a wiki page, are on the server. The engine that forms the core of the software—also called a wiki engine—renders the content in the same way a Web browser renders pages.

In a client-side wiki setup, individual computers act as servers, only the data files are located on the central server, which acts as a database. All the execution needed to convert the wiki text into a normal display page is found in the browser used by each terminal.

Similarly, all the tools for creating, editing, saving and managing documents and schedules, or for taking any other action, are present in the browser as a plugin. Such plugins are available as downloads for most browsers such as Mozilla and Firefox; other browsers such as Flock have these plug-ins bundled with the installation files.

This flexibility afforded by the application makes it highly customisable. You can decide where to host the application, depending on the size of the wiki and the number of users.

The biggest hurdle in implementing a tool like the wiki is convincing people about the feasibility of the software

The Change Challenge

According to Cunningham, wikis are designed with the philosophy of making it easy to correct mistakes, rather than making it difficult to make them. The most common grouse against the use of wikis is also its biggest plus—anyone can open and edit or create a page in a wiki.

To keep vandals away and to verify the validity of an addition or editing, wikis provide for a 'Recent Changes' link. This gives a list of all the additions and changes done to a particular wiki within a certain timeframe.

Some wikis can also filter this list and remove minor edits as well as changes made to the document by bots that crawl the Web. This feature is very useful when your wiki is open to the Internet. A typical case would be for documentation of software or program development with developers strewn across the globe, as is the case with development of most open source tools and application software.

In addition to the 'Recent Changes' link, every wiki has a Revision History, which shows previous page versions, and where the differences between the two versions are highlighted. This enables any person accessing a particular page to make note of the change, and this comes in handy for processes that change frequently and need to be documented.

A regular wiki user can view the differences in an edit listed on the 'Recent Changes' page and, if something is an unacceptable edit, he can consult the history and restore a previous revision.

Apart from this, the tool has various other in-built customised filters, that provide high levels of content control. Some Wikis use login and password authentication and can thus track which user made changes and when. This type of Wiki is used in offices. Other tools include ones that monitor a page quality, and send alerts to the administrator whenever modifications are marked on a page. This feature is useful for pages that detail a particular method to do a process or to house case studies, where changes are not frequent.

The Collaborative Game

The biggest hurdle in implementing a tool like the wiki is convincing people about the feasibility of the software. Training and incentives are very important to get people accustomed to, and contribute to, the system. A major shift in the mindset of the company, however big, is necessary to implement the wiki; the move will have to be from corporate to co-operative. ■

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The Easy Wiki Way

Wiki Syntax	HTML	Rendered Output
A simple WYSIWYG format makes typing out a text in a wiki so easy. What are the advantages?	 A simple WYSIWYG format makes typing out a text in a wiki so easy. What are the advantages? 	A simple WYSIWYG format makes typing out a text in a wiki so easy. What are the advantages?
Using Wiki does away with the cumbersome HTML codes.	 Using Wiki does away with the cumbersome HTML codes. 	Using Wiki does away with the cumbersome HTML codes.

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